NeuroText

EEG representation learning for sentence retrieval

Can EEG retrieve sentence meaning beyond matched negative controls?

ZuCo 1.0 + 2.0 | Statistical ridge · CNN · SSL · frozen LaBraM

Ziad Elsayed | University project

18 wider-grid exploratory transfer evaluations; participant independence unresolved.

Define the prediction task

Fixed-pool retrieval with unseen readers

1. Encode a sentence-length EEG recording.
2. Predict its location in a frozen sentence-embedding space.
3. Rank unique candidate sentences by cosine similarity.
4. Evaluate Recall@1/5/10 and mean reciprocal rank (MRR).

Above random ranking alone is insufficient: real EEG must beat matched controls.

Data preparation and quality audit

Normal reading · 105 ordered channels · resampled to 200 Hz

ZuCo 1.0

12 readers

3,356 prepared observations

3,349 after duration QC

ZuCo 2.0

18 readers

5,911 prepared observations

5,884 after duration QC

19-channel LaBraM adaptation is a separate cohort: 3,345 / 5,838 observations.

One shared, memory-conscious implementation

Windows + Colab clients use the same Python package

LOAD

Lazy signal arrays

Audited manifests

REPRESENT

Statistics / CNN

SSL / frozen LaBraM

ALIGN

Train-only scaling

Validation selection

RANK

MiniLM targets

Cosine retrieval

Local hardware: RTX 3050 with 4 GB VRAM; lazy loading limits memory use.

Shared code and documented inputs make weak results inspectable and reproducible.

Controls make the central comparison

Hold out subjects; fit preprocessing on training observations only

Real EEG: original signals and true sentence pairing.

Gaussian: matched per-channel scale, independently generated noise.

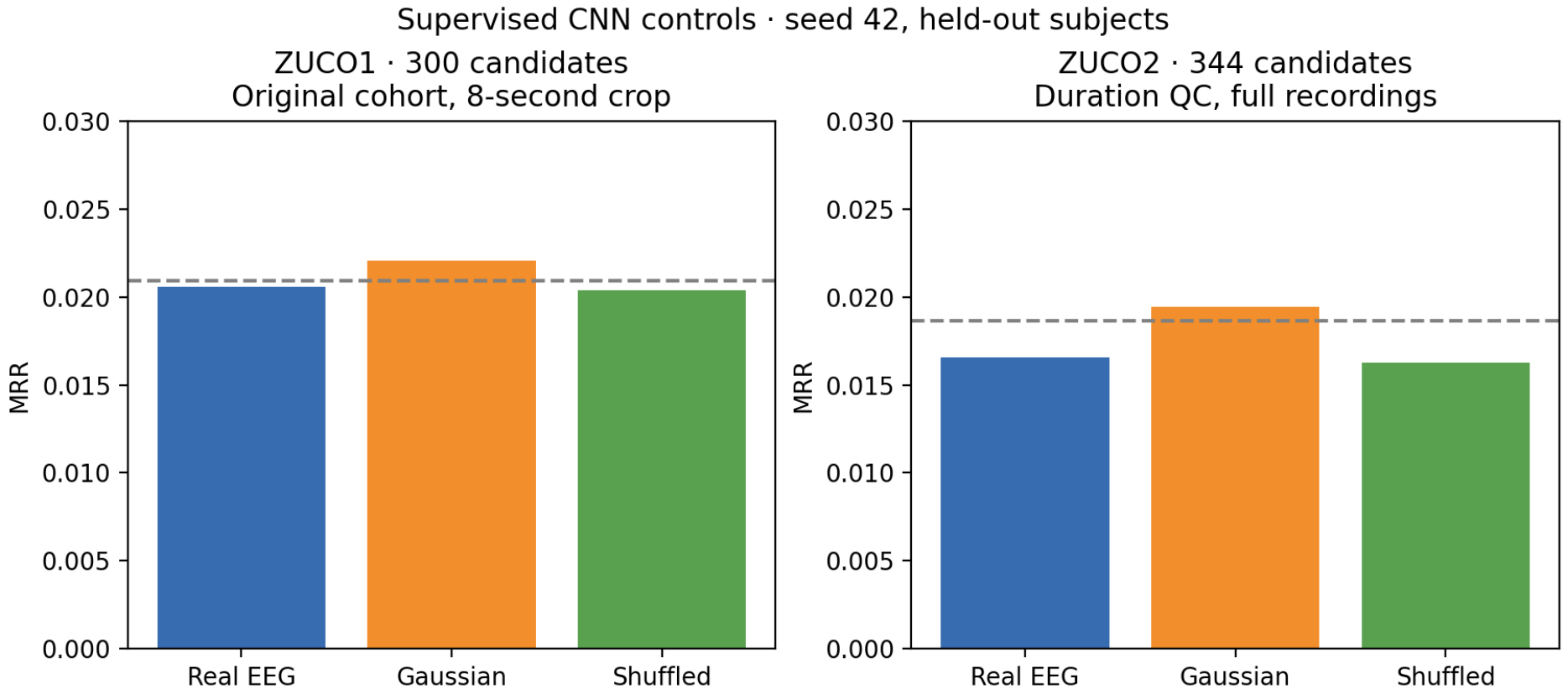
Shuffled: separately trained model with incorrect sentence pairing.

Compare within the same cohort, split, seed and candidate pool.

Single-split differences are descriptive; no statistical significance is claimed.

Supervised CNN: Gaussian matches top-1 hits

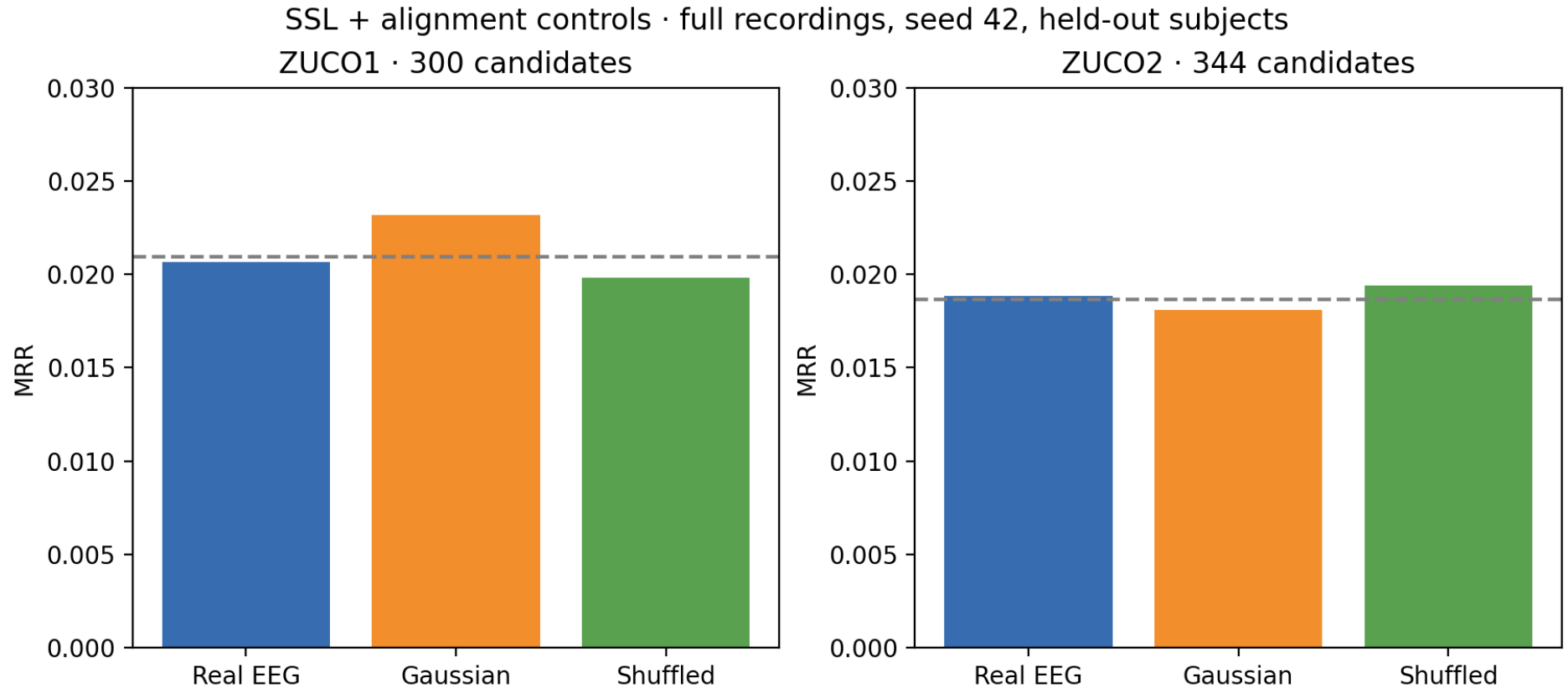
Seed 42 · ZuCo1: 592 queries / 300 candidates · ZuCo2: 984 / 344



Gaussian MRR exceeds real EEG in both datasets.

SSL: reconstruction does not establish decoding

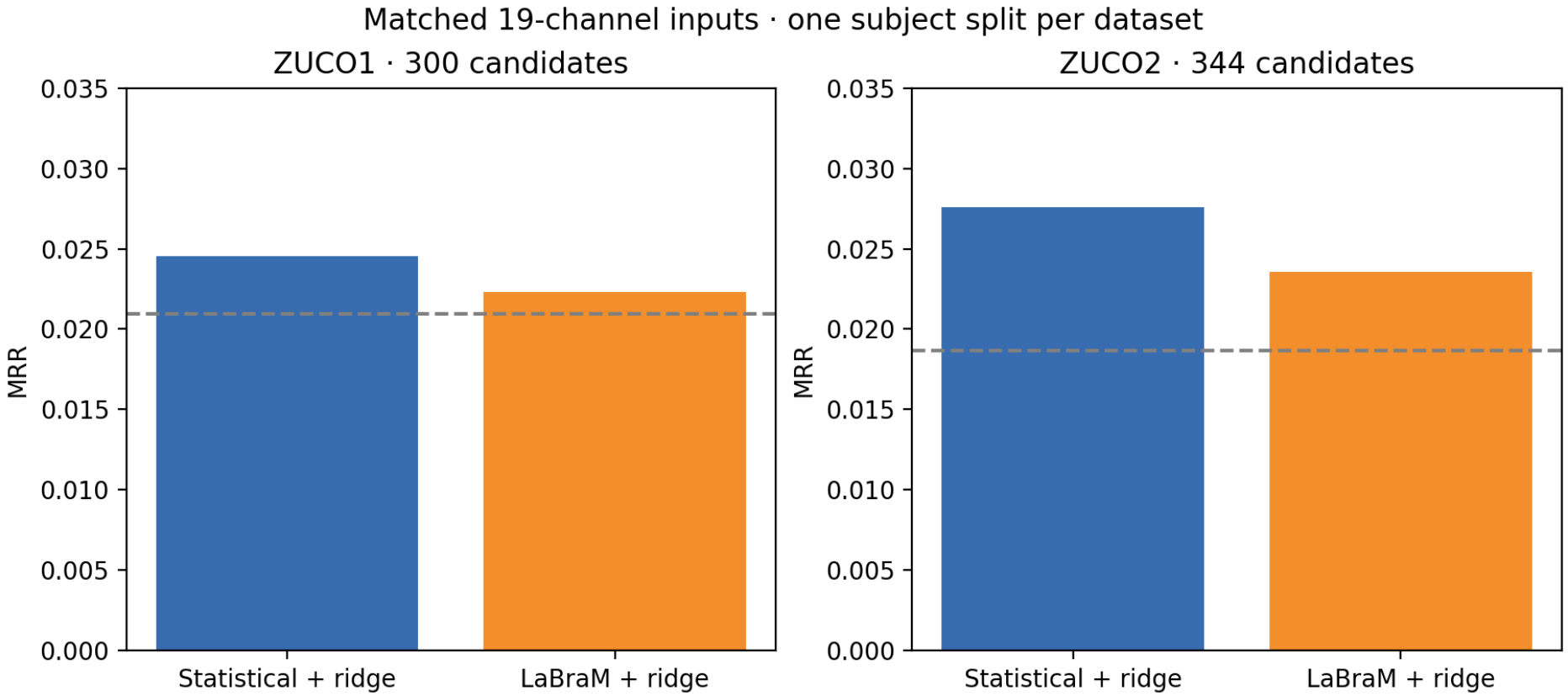
Full recordings · duration QC · Gaussian control covers both learned stages



No consistent retrieval advantage for real EEG over the controls.

Frozen LaBraM against matched statistical features

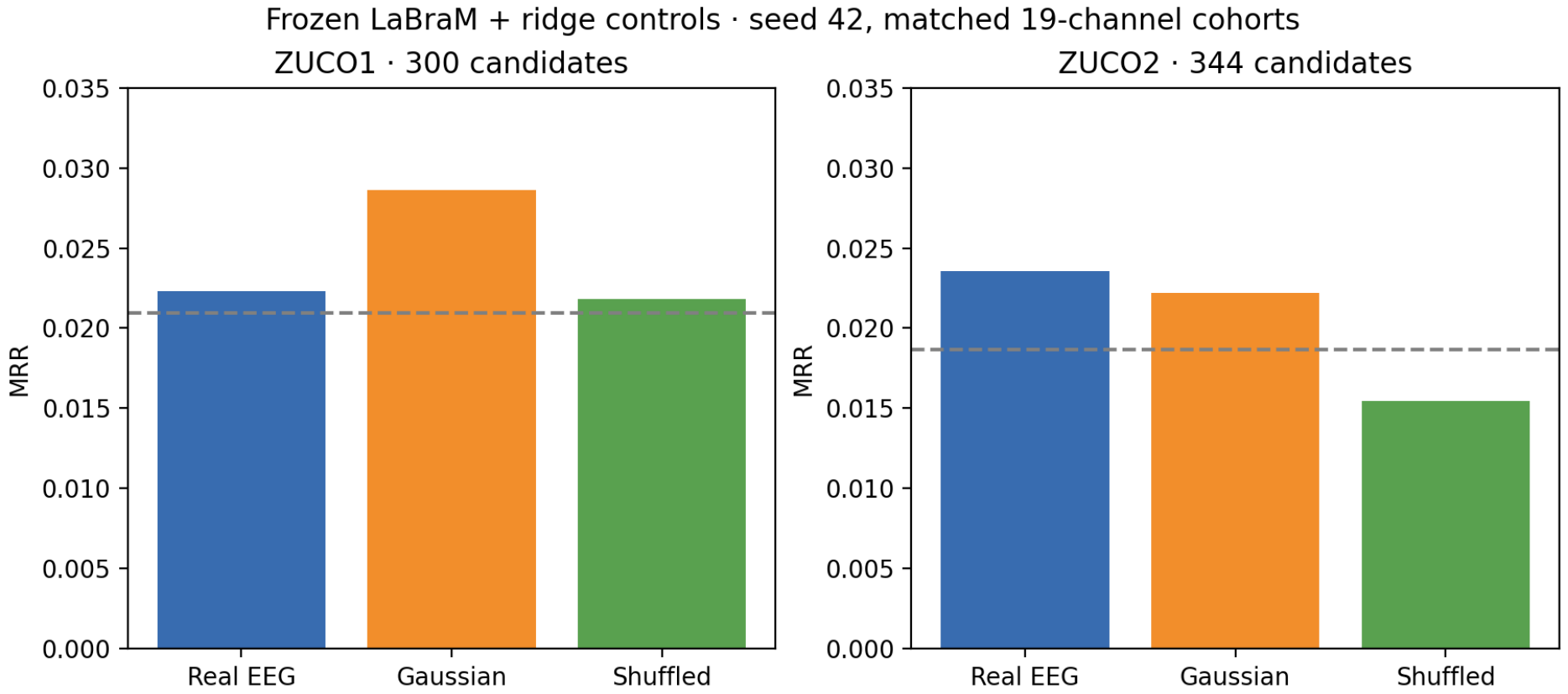
Identical adapted signals · 19 mapped electrodes · whole-second support



Statistical features have higher top-1 and MRR on both reported splits.

LaBraM controls limit the interpretation

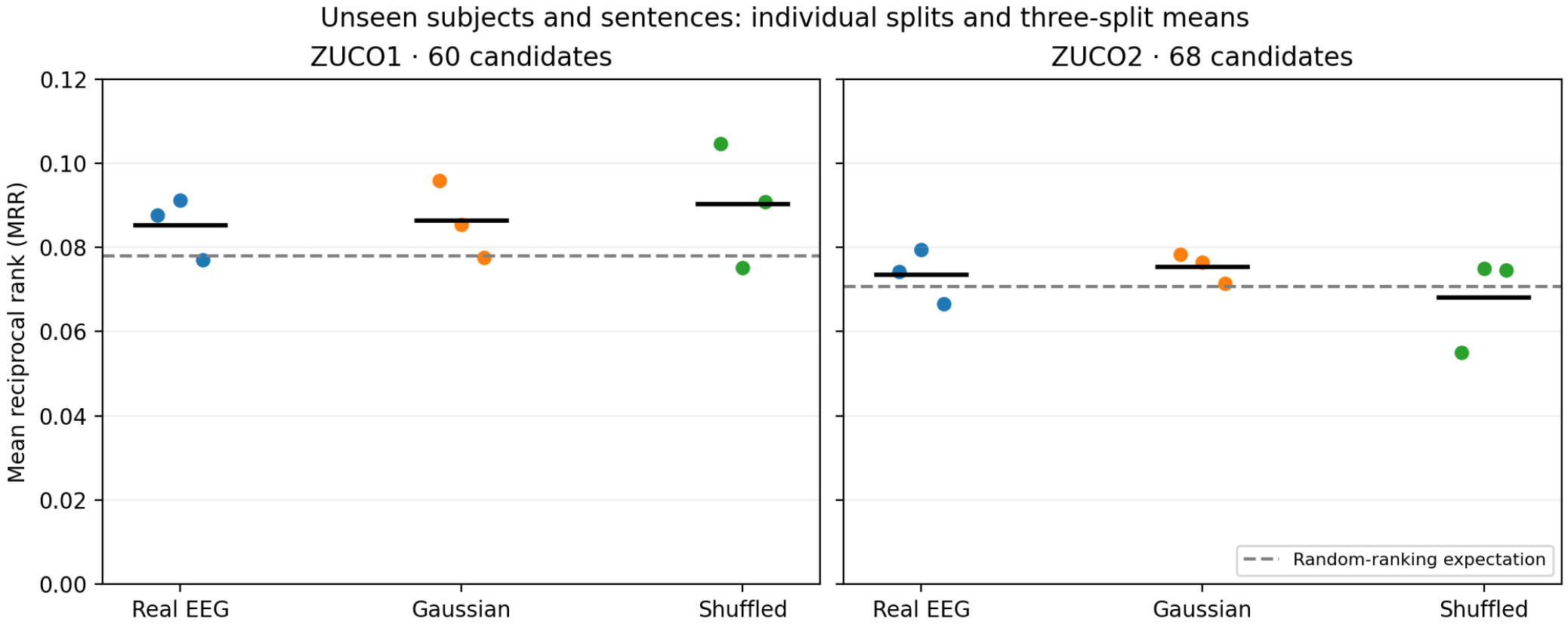
Frozen backbone · separately fit ridge models · same adapted cohort and split



No consistent real-EEG superiority under this exploratory adaptation.

Unseen subjects and unseen sentence content

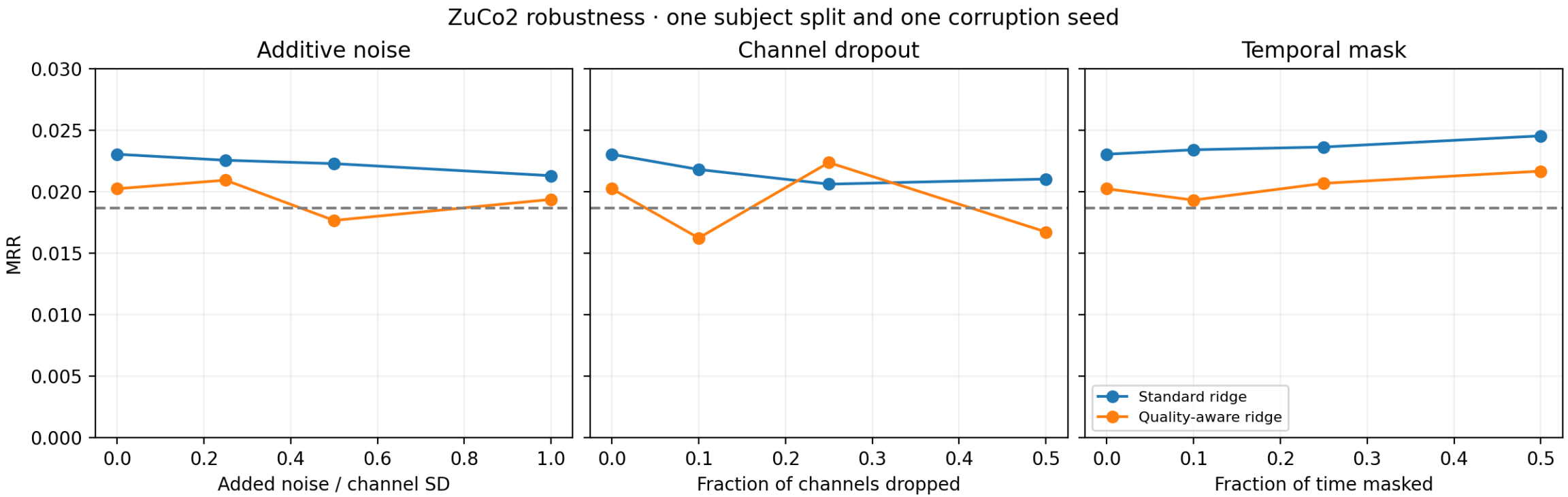
Ridge · seeds 42, 43, 44 · 60 candidates in ZuCo1 / 68 in ZuCo2



Real EEG exceeds Gaussian MRR on only one of three seeds in each dataset.

Quality weighting shows no consistent benefit

ZuCo2 ridge · 984 queries / 344 candidates · one split and corruption seed



Quality-aware MRR is lower in 8 of 9 nonzero corruption conditions.

Published work: compare protocols before scores

Generation, classification and retrieval measure different tasks

EEG-to-text papers often report BLEU / ROUGE for language generation.

LaBraM originally reports classification tasks.

Our task reports Recall@K / MRR for a fixed sentence pool.

The original AAAI 2022 repository documents an evaluation correction.

Primary-source protocol review is complete; competitive numerical ranking is unsupported.

Exploratory transfer uses source-only selection

18 wider-grid evaluations · both directions · seeds 42, 43, 44

Train signal normalization and ridge on source training observations only.

Select alpha by source-validation MRR across seven fixed values.

Compare real EEG with separately trained Gaussian and shuffled controls.

Participant independence across releases remains unresolved.

50 shared texts remain in the target pools; strict transfer is still unexecuted.

Wider-grid results: ZuCo1 to ZuCo2

5,884 queries · 344 candidates · the same target cohort at every seed

Seed	Condition	Alpha	Source val MRR	Recall@1	Target MRR
42	Real	100	0.028249	0.340%	0.018732
42	Gaussian	100	0.025700	0.306%	0.019507
42	Shuffled	100000	0.020376	0.272%	0.018177
43	Real	1000	0.024743	0.255%	0.019005
43	Gaussian	0.1	0.027825	0.493%	0.020673
43	Shuffled	0.1	0.027011	0.238%	0.017791
44	Real	0.1	0.022323	0.238%	0.017851
44	Gaussian	10	0.020144	0.238%	0.017859
44	Shuffled	100	0.022480	0.238%	0.018772

Real EEG MRR is below Gaussian MRR on all three seeds.

Wider-grid results: ZuCo2 to ZuCo1

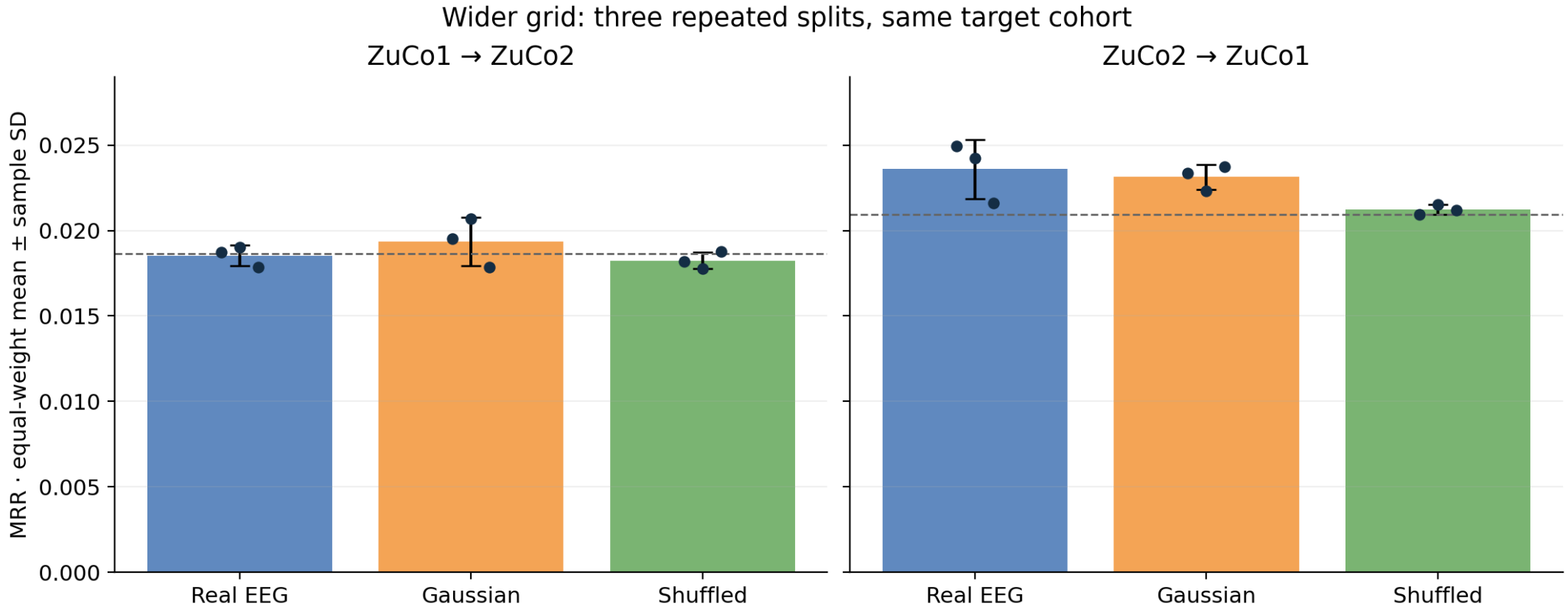
3,349 queries · 300 candidates · the same target cohort at every seed

Seed	Condition	Alpha	Source val MRR	Recall@1	Target MRR
42	Real	1000	0.026690	0.627%	0.024933
42	Gaussian	1000	0.024125	0.448%	0.023354
42	Shuffled	100000	0.019260	0.299%	0.020941
43	Real	1000	0.024824	0.508%	0.024221
43	Gaussian	1	0.025861	0.358%	0.022323
43	Shuffled	1000	0.020172	0.388%	0.021521
44	Real	100000	0.021306	0.388%	0.021621
44	Gaussian	10	0.025757	0.567%	0.023748
44	Shuffled	1	0.016905	0.418%	0.021185

Real EEG MRR exceeds Gaussian on seeds 42 and 43; the sign reverses on seed 44.

Wider-grid means remain close to controls

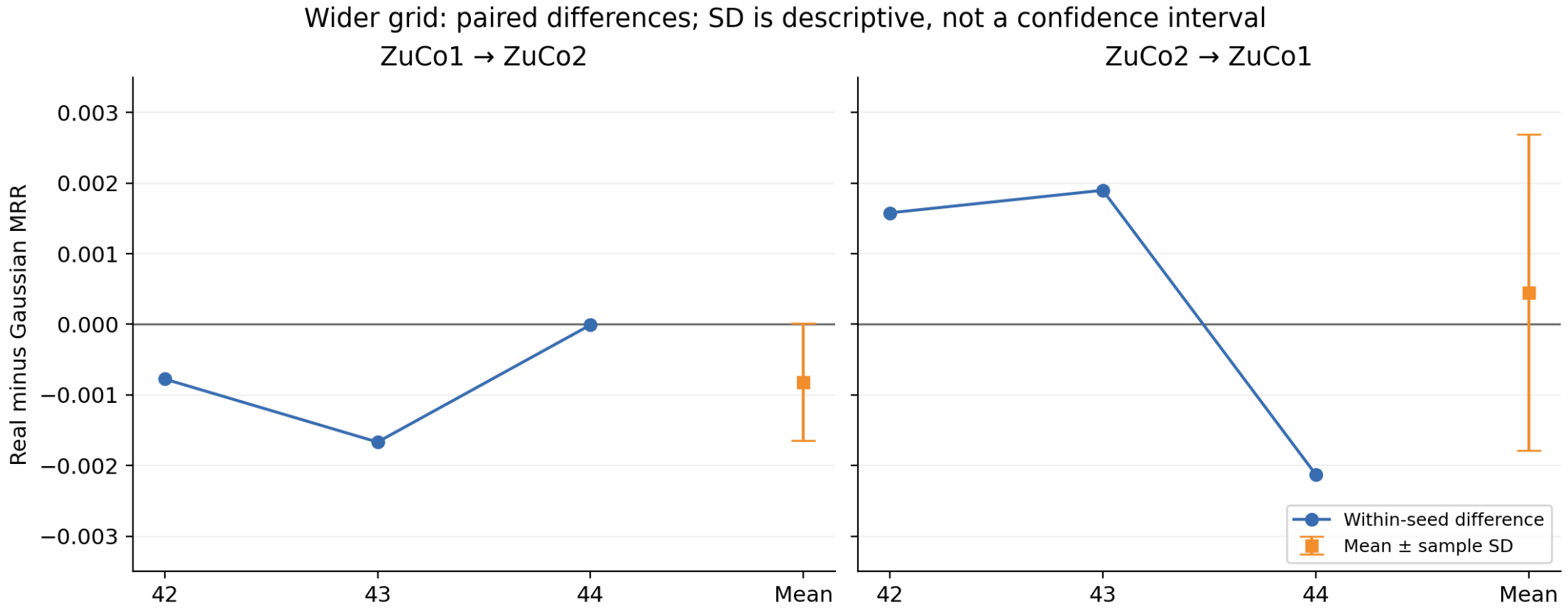
Equal-weight seed means · sample SD · individual seed points



Repeated splits reuse target participants and queries; SD is descriptive.

Real-minus-Gaussian differences change by seed

Pair within direction and seed before calculating mean and sample SD



Forward ΔMRR −0.000817 ± 0.000831; reverse +0.000450 ± 0.002237.

Original and wider grids are separate experiments

Seed 42 only · original grid ends at 100 · wider grid ends at 100,000

Direction	Condition	Original α / MRR	Wider α / MRR
1 to 2	Real	100 / 0.018732	100 / 0.018732
1 to 2	Gaussian	100 / 0.019507	100 / 0.019507
1 to 2	Shuffled	1 / 0.019001	100000 / 0.018177
2 to 1	Real	10 / 0.022941	1000 / 0.024933
2 to 1	Gaussian	100 / 0.024007	1000 / 0.023354
2 to 1	Shuffled	10 / 0.021036	100000 / 0.020941

Only the wider grid has seeds 42–44; do not pool the grids as extra repeats.

Archive and recorded software validation

139 passed · 2 optional skips · 0 deselected

Full configs, candidate keys, split digests and evaluation JSON are archived.

Two official-weight tests skip because EEG_LABRAM_CACHE is unset.

Integration skip: no network download during unit tests.

Extraction skip: optional official weights on synthetic fixtures.

The previously excluded 513 MiB MATLAB test was included and passed.

Recorded validation is preserved; consolidation launches no experiments.

These configurations do not show reliable retrieval

Matched controls and repeated splits limit the interpretation

These configurations do not demonstrate reliable retrieval beyond controls.

Forward real MRR trails Gaussian on all three seeds.

Reverse differences change sign, with only a small positive mean.

Participant independence remains unresolved; strict transfer is unexecuted.

The findings do not establish that EEG contains no semantic information.